Slop / University

Signed Without Scrolling

Typologising the Human Sponsors of Junior Netball's Automated Team-Selection App

Marit Osayande · Renke Sabel — School of Continuous Improvement

Motivation

Junior sport's shift to automated team-selection apps assigns each squad a nominal human "sponsor" of record. Little is known about what oversight that role performs once the algorithm returns a team sheet.

Research questions

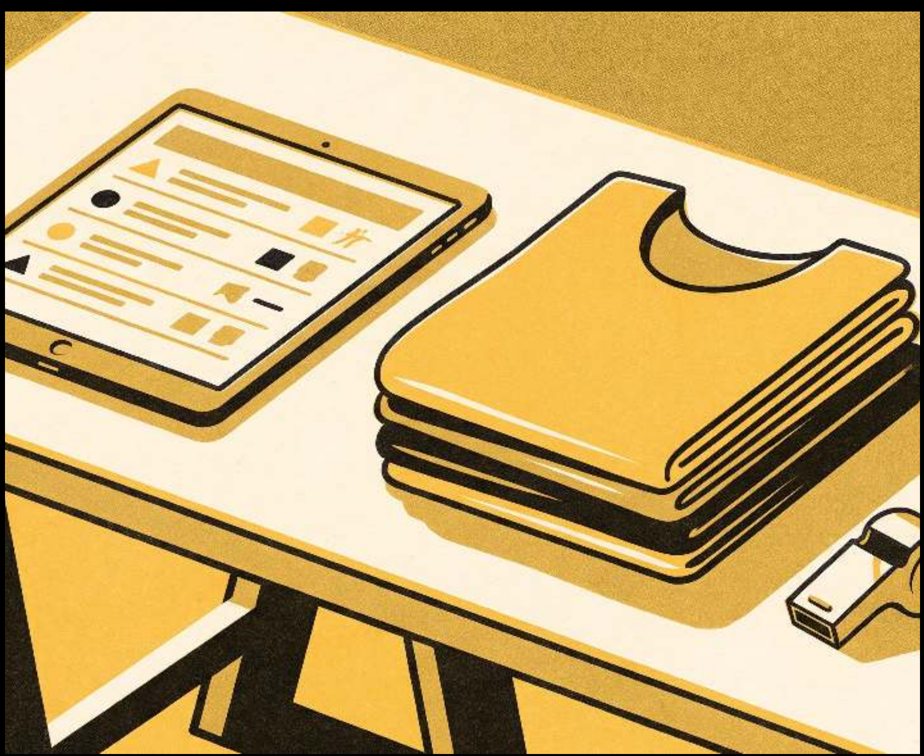
- How do sponsors describe their own oversight of the app's selections?
- Does the resulting typology track club size or sponsor tenure?
- Do overriding sponsors act before or after the sheet is posted?

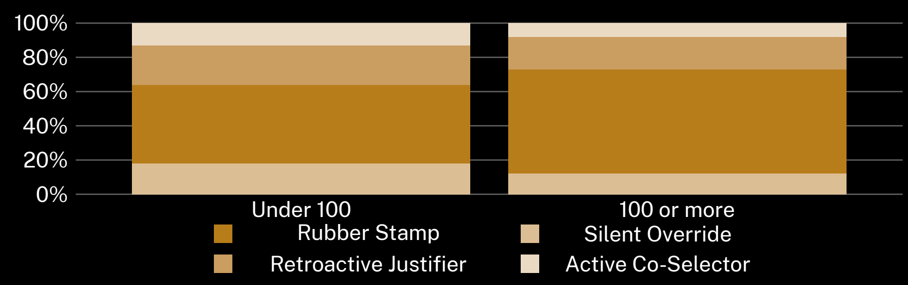
Study design

- n = 64 sponsors · 18 suburban netball clubs · semi-structured interview
- open coding to a four-category typology; inter-rater $\kappa = 0.78$
- category set pre-registered; no post-hoc merging

What we found

Sponsors cluster into two categories — Rubber Stamp and Retroactive Justifier — more often than the two categories built to signal active oversight. Category membership tracks club size more closely than tenure in role.





Sponsors at clubs fielding 100 or more juniors self-identified as a Rubber Stamp in 61% of interviews, against 46% at clubs under 100, interviewed March–June 2026.

Implications & where next

A named human sponsor does not guarantee a reviewed decision; scale appears to compress oversight rather than distribute it. The category built to capture genuine override was the rarest category in both club-size bands, and the clubs most reliant on the app were the least likely to have anyone reading past its summary screen. Whether a sponsor's self-description holds up against what the app actually logged is the open question the interview data cannot settle on its own. Next: instrument the app's own audit log against each sponsor's self-report, and track whether a season's worth of rubber-stamping shifts a club toward retiring the role altogether.

Selected references

1. Elish, M. C. (2019). Moral crumple zones: Cautionary tales in human-robot interaction. *Engaging Science, Technology, and Society*, 5, 40–60. doi:10.17351/ests2019.260
2. Green, B., & Chen, Y. (2019). The principles and limits of algorithm-in-the-loop decision making. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction*, 3(CSCW), 1–24. doi:10.1145/3359152
3. Lyell, D., & Coiera, E. (2017). Automation bias and verification complexity: a systematic review. *Journal of the American Medical Informatics Association*, 24(2), 423–431. doi:10.1093/jamia/ocw105
4. Green, B. (2022). The flaws of policies requiring human oversight of government algorithms. *Computer Law & Security Review*, 45, 105681. doi:10.1016/j.clsr.2022.105681
5. Chikere, I., & Ntuli, B. (2026). The sign-off outran the reading: The 2026-2031 Strategic Plan names an accountable reviewer for every AI-assisted decision, then builds a tool to help them sign faster. *Slop University Strategic Plan*. doi:10.5555/slop.d2jro8

We thank the committees of the eighteen participating clubs. Supported by a School of Continuous Improvement seed grant.

Sponsor interviews de-identified at transcription; no junior player data retained; category set pre-registered.